Vocabulary

Neutral and sensationalist language

Choose the correct options to complete the text.

Police (1) *vow / tout* to apologise to entertainer

The Chief Inspector of Westfield Constabulary **(2)** *spilt / caught* the beans on what actually took place at last week's street dance festival.

It had been reported that a local entertainer had been responsible for ripping the city flag at the start of the festivities and a uniformed officer didn't beat about the **(3)** *chest / bush* when it came to naming the culprit: a 15-foot clown on stilts! This was **(4)** *news / new* to the man in question, who had actually been off his stilts when the accident happened.

However, footage later emerged that a **(5)** *clash / leak* between the mounted policeman and a pet dog had actually caused the flag to get ripped. The dog, who 'wouldn't say boo to a **(6)** *goose / duck'* according to its owner, got frightened by the horse and panicked. This **(7)** *provoked / ousted* the horse to abruptly jump onto its hind legs and cause damage to the flag in the process.

The police have promised to apologise to the victim for the mistake and **(8)** *slammed / quashed* the unnamed officer for pointing the finger at the innocent performer.

Binomials

Match sentence halves to make correct sentences.

A	This movie was by and	1	error because no one's perfect.
B	To be honest, my twins are like chalk and	2	tested way of getting people on side.
C	You can only succeed via trial and	3	cheese as far as character is concerned.
D	This recipe by my grandma is a tried and	4	large the best performance by the Bollywood actor.
E	What we must do today is look at the ins and	5	outs of the commercial viability of the product.
F	I prefer meeting in person rather than the back and	6	forth nature of online communication.
G	The injury was such that it was touch and	7	dried as people are making out.
H	This netball match is not as cut and	8	go for my aunt at times.

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Language focus

Cohesion

Choose the correct options to complete the sentences.

1 The *ones* / *one* that caught my eye the most were the paintings of daffodils.

2 The journalist revealed her sources, and in doing *such* / *so*, was never trusted again.

3 *Every* / *Each* of my family members supports the others in whatever they choose to pursue.

4 *Ours* / *Our* isn't the best of the projects, but we did spend the most time on it.

5 It *must* / *would* have been the storm that knocked the tree down, nothing else could have.

6 *Theirs* / *Their* was the funniest performance of the night because they're both so naturally comical.

7 Could I have the *ones* / *one* that is covered with chocolate? It's my absolute favourite.

8 On the subject of sport, would you rather watch *sport* / *it* or play *it* / *sport?*

Language focus

Demonstratives

Choose the correct options to complete the sentences.

1 Look, there's *that* / *this* girl from my class who hates sweets – how can you hate sweets?

2 *That* / *This* cat has got nine lives for sure. He's been missing for ten days and now see him strolling back in right as rain!

3 *Those* / *These who throw litter out of their car windows should be made to do community service.*

4 I'm not sure the committee has really thought *through these* / *those sort* of problems. They're more focused on the day-to-day issues.

5 Who asks *that* / *this* type of question in a family group? I wanted the ground to swallow me up!

6 *These* / *Those* who bought their car after 2015 are exempt from paying the emissions charge.

7 *That* / *This* house of ours is a crumbling wreck. Just look at the walls! It needs so much work, I'd rather move.

8 They talk about local investment, but how have any of *those* / *these* so-called investments helped the local community?

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Word formation

Complete the gap in each sentence with the correct form of the word given.

One day I was travelling overseas when I came across someone from my own village. This was something **(1)** _____ **(EXPECT)** to say the least. There are only around 300 **(2)** _____ **(INHABIT)** living there! So, when I saw the owner of the corner shop in an isolated mountain town in Canada, I could **(3)** _____ **(HARD)** believe my eyes.

I walked straight over and said hello. To my surprise and I'll admit, **(4)** _____ **(DISAPPOINT)**, he didn't have the foggiest who I was. How could this be? Someone must have got their wires **(5)** _____ **(CROSS)** and I felt sure it wasn't me.

So, when I got back, I made a point of **(6)** _____ **(HEAD)** straight for the shop to set the record straight. But again, he was **(7)** _____ **(CLUE)**.

Finally, he owned up and said he has an identical twin brother. It happens all the time, **(8)** _____ **(APPARENT)**! Good to know I'm not going mad!

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Reading and Use of English

Part 6 Gapped text

You are going to read an article. Seven paragraphs have been removed from the article. Choose from the paragraphs A – H the one which fits each gap. There is one extra paragraph which you do not need to use.

How much news can children take?

It wasn't so long ago that the news was something we could dip in or out of. If we chose not to watch television or have our daily newspaper delivered, we could pretty much avoid all the nastiness that goes on in the world. True, it was impossible to completely bury our heads in the sand, but it was, at least, easier to focus on the here and now in our neck of the woods. **1** ☐

As adults, most of us are able to weed out the irrelevant sensationalist rubbish, discarding the click bait that doesn't need to be stored inside our heads. Children, on the other hand, are less able to do this. This may be as a result of peer pressure, a natural inquisitiveness, a lack of life experience or a combination of all of these elements. **2** ☐

As a rule of thumb though, this age tends to be around seven. This is because, before this age, children find it difficult to understand the concepts that might be written about. For example, if they read that the world is spinning faster than it has before, they may well be sick with worry that we're all going to fall off! Obviously, these thoughts can lead to a great deal of anxiety in a young mind. **3** ☐

As soon as this communication begins, it's time to look at the news from a different standpoint. Let's be honest, unless you're living on a desert island without Wi-Fi, you don't have much choice! According to Ofcom, the UK's media regulator, more than 97% of homes with children aged between 0 and 18 in the UK had internet access in 2022. Wouldn't it therefore make sense to look for the numerous benefits of reading the news within these parameters? **4** ☐

Another advantage is that reading the news promotes social cohesion. It's easy to simply focus on all the bad events. But, flick through a newspaper or take a look at a news website and you'll see that there are also human-interest stories, feel-good articles and all kinds of topics, from the latest scientific discovery to charities that are helping people in need – perfect for building emotional intelligence. **5** ☐

Finally, reading the news can actually reduce anxiety about world events. Children want to know what's going on; they want to be involved. How often do parents keep things from their kids in a bid to protect them? And how often does the child know that something is wrong but the lack of communication makes them more worried? The answer is … all the time! **6** ☐

First News is a relatively young site that is a good example of this. Starting in 2006, it has grown to a readership of 2.2 million young people. It prides itself on being both independently owned and having no political affiliations. And that's not all! Over half of UK schools subscribe to it, cementing its reputation as a source of news for kids. Their ethos is that the more we inform the next generation, the better the world will become. **7** ☐

In short, constant news is here to stay. We can't stop the bombardment of information onto our televisions, tablets and phones and resistance is futile. What we can do is guide our children to suitable news websites and discuss the good as well as bad things that are going on in our world. It's their future and, with any luck, what they learn about the world today could help them to change it for the better.

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A In addition, your child will begin to form their own ideas and opinions about current affairs. This in itself could improve communication between members of your household, and having some lively and fun debates teaches listening skills, understanding and respect for different views. What a great set of skills to take into adulthood!

B Admittedly, you can apply parental controls on these sites. The main sticking point here is that you can't guarantee other care givers will follow suit. So, if their besties have access and they don't, you don't have to be a rocket scientist to work out what they'll do. Therefore, parental control is seemingly pointless.

C This is why, contrary to what some of us may think, parents should discuss news articles with their offspring rather than keeping them away from these stories or brushing off any concerns their children might have about what is in the news. Children often have vivid imaginations and they may need our help to interpret the words and bring their thoughts back down to earth.

D Its forefather is Newsround, a children's news programme which has been running on the BBC for over 50 years. This was one of the world's first news shows that was designed specifically for younger people. Today, it has an online presence as well and is aimed at 6–12-year-olds.

E Not so these days. Whether it's social media, 24-hour rolling news channels or, dare I say it, TikTok, the news appears to be omnipresent in our lives. It's practically impossible to be out of the loop for any length of time, and many people are prone to doomscrolling on a daily basis.

F One is the fact that they're reading full stop. They're more likely to reach reading targets at school, and this will have a broader positive impact. Reading from a young age has been proven to improve memory and logic. Furthermore, gaining confidence as a reader from an early age sets them up to be life-long readers, with all the joys that brings.

G That said, it doesn't mean you should give children free rein to trawl the internet for stories! In the same way you can discuss what they've read, you can guide them towards reputable and child-friendly sites. By doing this, you can be confident that although they will have access to positive and negative stories, they will be written in a sensitive way using appropriate language.

H That leads us onto the question of when the right time to let our kids be exposed to the news might be. The simple answer is that this very much depends on the child. This involves constant and careful interaction and evaluation of the individual. And how many parents have time for this in our ever-busy lives?

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Reading and Use of English

Part 2 Open cloze

Read the text below and think of the word which answer best fits each space. Use only one word in each space. There is an example at the beginning.

The first television news

In 1954, the BBC (British Broadcasting Corporation) wrote **(0)** _____*ITSELF*_____ into the history books by broadcasting the first news bulletin.

News and Newsreel was made **(1)** _____ of a news summary, still images, and films. Newsreaders Richard Baker and John Snagge were offscreen, as it was thought that their appearance could **(2)** _____ distract the viewers. This is in stark contrast to today's presenters who are expected to **(3)** _____ centre stage.

The initial criticism of the programme was the extent to **(4)** _____ it failed to illustrate the stories it covered. At **(5)** _____ time, the then Director General, Sir Ian Jacob explained, 'A good many of the main news items are not easily made visual.' The visual content was therefore considered substandard to the sound quality the corporation prided itself **(6)** _____.

In **(7)** _____ of this difficult start, by 1955, television news had doubled its airtime and the newsreaders, now onscreen, proved popular.

This is a far **(8)** _____ from the 24-hour international news coverage we are familiar with on BBC News 24 today.

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Listening

Part 4 Multiple matching

You will hear five short extracts in which people are talking about the face-to-face communication at work. While you listen, you must complete the table with the letters for both tasks.

TASK ONE: Choose from the list (A–H) what each person does for a living.

A office worker
B medical professional
C voluntary worker
D language teacher
E childminder
F sales assistant
G sports teacher
H landscape gardener

TASK TWO: Choose from the list (A–H) which benefit face-to-face communication has over online communication each speaker mentions.

A It reduces distractions.
B It generates ideas.
C It provides a break from engaging with a screen.
D It's easier to understand non-verbal clues.
E It's better for engaging in small talk.
F It facilitates forming new relationships.
G It increases engagement between the speakers.
H It is better suited to discussing sensitive issues.

	TASK ONE	TASK TWO
SPEAKER 1	**(1)** _____	**(6)** _____
SPEAKER 2	**(2)** _____	**(7)** _____
SPEAKER 3	**(3)** _____	**(8)** _____
SPEAKER 4	**(4)** _____	**(9)** _____
SPEAKER 5	**(5)** _____	**(10)** _____

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Writing

Part 2 Article

Write your answer in 280–320 words. You must use grammatically correct sentences with accurate spelling and punctuation in a style appropriate for the situation.

You work for a university news site. The editor has asked for ideas for a new section. You have been asked to write a report for the editor assessing two new topics and their suitability for the site. You should briefly describe each topic, as well as the kind of stories they could cover. You should also evaluate why each would appeal to the readership of the news site and recommend one of them.

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Speaking

Part 3 Long turn

Here is a question for you to answer, with some ideas to use if you like. Talk for one minute.

How do traditional news sources, such as newspapers and television, differ from social media in the way they present information?

– reliability and misinformation

– citizen journalism

– diversity of perspectives

Part 1 Interview

Answer the six questions. Talk for no more than one minute for each question.

1 Which current topical issues are most important to you? Why?

2 To what degree do you rely on social media or informal networks for news and information?

3 How do you determine the reliability and trustworthiness of the information you consume?

4 What role do journalists play in maintaining public trust in traditional media? How important is this?

5 How does the speed at which news spreads, particularly through digital platforms, affect the quality and accuracy of information?

6 To what extent do you think media literacy education is essential for the public to navigate and critically assess news sources in today's information landscape?

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